

19% COUPLES PREFER SEX IN THE BATHROOM WHILE 8% PREFER THE KITCHEN

of Intimacy

THE URBAN INDIAN'S APPETITE FOR EVERYTHING, EXCEPT SEX WITHIN MARRIAGE, HAS INCREASED. IN THE FOUR YEARS SINCE THE LAST SURVEY, IT SEEMS THAT MARRIAGE IS THE ONLY THING COUPLES HAVE IN COMMON. ON FREQUENCY, IMPORTANCE AND REASONS FOR HAVING SEX, MEN AND WOMEN HAVE WILDLY DIVERGENT VIEWS.

■ By Patricia Uberoi

Whether one likes it or not, sex surveys of the Indian middle class are coming in thick and fast. Initially, no doubt, these surveys had a certain shock value, like the post-War Kinsey reports which revealed that the Americans were not totally enamoured of the missionary position and that homosexuality was a remarkably

common experience; or the post-feminist Hite Report that gave new credibility to the female orgasm. Now that they are routine media fare, Indian sex surveys must find different ways to appeal to the narcissistic self-fascination of India's expanding middle class.

For the Indian consumers of such surveys, evidence of the liberalisation of sexual mores gives rise to collective frisson, if not also

to crippling dread of sexual inadequacy and moral panic. On the other hand, if surveys suggest that nothing much is changing—and the continued prevalence of "arranged marriage" is a case in point—this is equally a cause for public excitement because it contradicts the expectation that Indian society, like the economy, is liberalising at a very fast rate. In fact, of course, you cannot expect to see an 8 to 10 per cent an-

nual increase in sexual voracity any more than you can expect to discern definitive trends in sexual behaviour between INDIA TODAY'S pioneering surveys of the sexual habits of Indian women and men in 2003 and 2004, and the present survey of 2007.

Sometimes taking a long-term perspective can put things in a better, or rather less breathless, proportion. For instance, about 70 years ago, an eminent Bombay

Did you have sexual partners before marriage? If yes, whom did you have sex with?

		MALE	FEMALE
Never had sex before marriage	69	55	83
Girlfriend/boyfriend	16	25	6
Casual acquaintances	7	10	3
Had paid sex	5	9	1
One night stand	4	7	2
Relatives	4	6	1

All figures in per cent. Figures add up to more than 100 because of multiple choices.

Did you ask your spouse if he/she was a virgin?



Yes 31
No 62



Yes 30
No 66

All figures in per cent. Rest: Don't know/Won't say.

SACRED MATTERS

Only 10 per cent of the respondents had sex with their fiancée before marriage while 5 per cent reported having had oral sex. More couples in smaller cities like Bangalore, Lucknow, Jaipur and Ahmedabad admitted to having pre-marital sex with their fiancée compared to the bigger cities. Delhi and Hyderabad surprise us with their primness with 57 and 56 per cent saying they shared no intimacies before marriage, not even kissing or holding hands.